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Farewell Fred Gaines

December 10, 2020 | Acorn, The (Agoura Hills, CA)
Author: The Acorn Staff | Section: Front Page | 679 Words
OpenURL Link

After almost a decade on the Calabasas City Council, Fred Gaines' time in civil service is drawing to a close.

The council met in a virtual meeting Dec. 2 to bid farewell to the 61-year-old Gaines, who announced earlier this year he would not seek reelection to a third term on the council.

Friends, colleagues and City Council members took the evening to remember his service in Calabasas as a commissioner and council member.

The digital event featured a video tribute to Gaines with clips from his time in office and well wishes from numerous friends and public figures who have worked with him over the years.

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel thanked Gaines for his dedication to public service and said he's modeled his own leadership style after Gaines' outgoing engagement with the public.

"He's been an extraordinary public servant and someone I've been privileged to learn from," Gabriel said. "I've learned a lot about public service through the example you've set, through the time we've spent together and watching you work, everything you do to be present, the incredible and obvious love you have for the community you've served."

Gaines, an attorney, took office in 2011 and served as mayor twice, most notably during the 2018 Woolsey fire. Before joining the council, he served on the city's Library Commission for 13 years and the Calabasas Civic Center Task Force for five years.

He was recently appointed to chair the board of the Valley Economic Alliance, a private, nonprofit economic development and marketing corporation.

James Bozajian, longtime council member, first met Gaines 35 years ago. Bozajian was an editor for the Daily Bruin, the student newspaper at UCLA. Gaines was on the board of regents. The two met again as residents of Calabasas and struck up a friendship.

Bozajian thanked Gaines for his tireless work for the city, even before joining the council. Gaines, he said, played an integral role in helping the city secure funding for its library and civic center, even dedicating nights and weekends to the project.

The two council members stand on opposite sides of the political spectrum—Gaines a Democrat and Bozajian a Republican— but Bozajian said that's been an essential component of their relationship.

"I've never enjoyed disagreeing with someone so much in my entire life. We've had our share of ups and downs. Anytime you want to come back and pick a fight, please feel free to do so," Bozajian said.

"Sometimes you get in a certain mindset and don't think outside of it, and Fred, unlike many other people, has made me question my views. He made me think and presented cogent arguments.

"I hope you continue to contribute to the city," Bozajian said, telling his friend, I'll miss you very much, and hopefully we'll continue our relationship off the council."

While Gaines opposed the dismissal this year of former city manager Gary Lysik, Bozajian supported the manager's ouster over alleged fiscal and ethics violations. The vote calling for Lysik's resignation last May was 3-2—with Gaines against the firing and Bozajian in favor.

Gaines thanked the digital audience for their kind words and said the evening will stick in his memory for the rest of his life.

He said looking back over his time in office there are several key moments that presented themselves as learning opportunities, chief among them was the Woolsey fire.

He urged the City Council to develop a sensible housing plan in the months ahead, to help vulnerable populations in their struggle to survive, to prepare residents for emergencies, and to make clean energy a city priority.

"We have built a very nice little city here in Calabasas. Now the question is, can we be great? Can we put the intelligence, the affluence, the kindness of Calabasas to work on the world's biggest problems?" Gaines said.

"The only way to change things is from a place of fairness and love and understanding," he said.

"We're not going to be able to do any of it unless we emerge from this pandemic with the fiscal creativity and bold leadership to control our city's pension liabilities and other revenues. Nothing could be worse than a return to normality."

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Acorn Staff, T. (2020, December 10). Farewell Fred Gaines.*Acorn, The (Agoura Hills, CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/17F47C604A0D8068.